

was the *Spirit of Tasmania*, and a spot of *Antiques Roadshow*-ing was more likely to kickstart my parents' hormones than his and mine.

Instead I reverted to lying to my dates. On one occasion, I shamefully fibbed to this first fella that, when I didn't have enough money for a night out, I had lost my wallet, and asked to reschedule. I should have suggested a frozen pizza on the couch at home, but can anybody like – or love – a cheapskate?

The IMF: Intimacy Monetary Fund

A little extra cash each week is sometimes necessary for getting acquainted with a sexy suitor because, during those giddy early days, it is hard to avoid socialising more. For me, that meant upping the budget by \$50 to make it \$250 a week, which wouldn't derail my goal. That extra cash comfortably allowed for a few extra wines.

I needn't have worried. For most singles, unanswered texts and ghosting – when dates vanish without explanation – are cause for angst. But when it happened with him during my early days of extreme saving, I was comforted by the slow slide into silence that defines the end of many modern relationships. I was free again to be frugal, and lopped my budget back to \$200 a week.

The next man I went out with received full disclosure but – mea culpa – not until a few weeks in. At the point he entered my life – we locked eyes at an auction I was reporting on and soon after re-matched on Tinder, thanks to low-range GPS, and recognised each other following an earlier encounter on the app – I had written the Pocket Money Savings Plan column that appears in this book's introduction. After several dates, I explained to him my unusual financial set-up, a conversation that was nudged along by the fact his friend had researched me online, as all good mates should do, and reported her findings to him. She'd read the column. He rolled over one morning and asked me about it out of the blue. There was nowhere to hide, except for under the doona, and I contemplated doing that.

It had been too early, and yet too late, for a money talk.

When I started the savings plan, I had estimated I could live on \$700 a fortnight, but had cut back enough that I was doing well on \$400 a fortnight. I liked him, so I upped my pocket money to the allowed \$350 a week so I could pay my way. During that romantic interlude, I decided to